

How to sell OKRs internally



Take your proposal to the meeting.

Use the field guide to prepare the problem, your proposal and your manager's questions.

Answer the questions before you meet your manager. Write in the spaces or keep your answers in a separate document. Then complete the proposal on page 8.

If you do not know an answer, record what you need to check and who can check it. Ask the teams involved before you promise their time.

WORK THROUGH THESE STEPS

1. Bring a concrete problem
2. Define the result you want
3. Make room for one cycle
4. Set the dates and reviews
5. Agree how you will decide afterwards
6. Prepare for your manager's questions

Then complete your proposal and check the worked example.

Bring a concrete problem

Choose one problem your manager needs to solve. Bring an example you can show.

Which problem needs attention?

Describe what people do or what happens. For example, teams discover too late that they need work from each other.

What happened in a recent example?

Record the date, the people or teams affected, and the evidence you can show.

What did that problem cost?

Use a missed date, repeated work, customer delays or time lost. Mark estimates as estimates.

Why does your manager need to act now?

Connect the problem to a result your manager is responsible for.

Use these answers for The problem in your proposal. Describe the problem and its cost in one or two sentences.

Define the result you want

OKR means Objectives and Key Results. An objective describes the result you want. A key result sets a measurable target and a deadline.

What should improve for customers or teams?

Describe the result, such as fewer avoidable delays. Completing a list of tasks does not show that the result improved.

How will you measure that result?

Define what you count, who or what you include, and where the data comes from.

What is the starting figure?

Record the number, the period measured and its source. If it is unknown, agree how to establish it before the cycle.

What target will you propose, and by when?

Agree whether the target is a firm commitment or an ambition to explore.

Use these answers for The shared goal. Write the objective, the measure, the starting figure, the target and the deadline.

Make room for one cycle

Propose one part of the service and a few teams. Keep the measures you already use for finances and daily work.

Which part of the service and which teams will take part?

State what stays outside the cycle. Any wider use needs another decision.

Who will organize the cycle and record decisions?

Name one person and check that they have time for the work.

Which manager can decide what work comes first?

Choose someone who can resolve conflicts between the teams and let tasks wait.

Which tasks can wait to make time for the cycle?

Agree this with the manager and the teams. Record what permission they need.

Which meeting or report will this replace?

Keep regular team planning. Keep the cycle separate from pay and individual performance reviews.

Complete The scope, Who runs the test and What this replaces. Add the required authority and time to Permission we need.

If leaders cannot agree on the problem, who decides or what work can wait, ask for those decisions first.

Set the dates and reviews

Choose a period that gives you time to observe the result. The example uses three months. Some results need longer or several cycles.

When will the cycle start and end?

Allow time to carry out the work and observe the result.

When will you review how the teams work?

Use an early review to check the shared goal, priority decisions, dependencies and meeting effort. Adjust the work then.

When will you review results and learning?

Set the final review after the last measured day. Compare the result with the starting figure and target.

Who will meet each week, and what will they record?

Agree the meeting length. Name who records results, obstacles, decisions, needs between teams and meeting time.

Complete The dates, The weekly meeting and What we will check. Give the early and final reviews different purposes.

For the customer-delay example, count each customer once by their agreed start date. Include customers still waiting. Report counts with percentages. If no customers were due to start, report that there is no customer evidence.

Agree how you will decide afterwards

Discuss these questions with the manager and teams before the cycle. Review the result together with decisions, learning and the effort required.

What evidence will you need for a useful review?

Agree the data and recorded decisions you need. There is no minimum customer count that fits every situation.

When would another limited cycle be useful?

Look for useful decisions and coordination, manageable meeting time and a reasoned next action. Missing the target does not automatically end the test.

What would make you change the approach?

Adapt if the cycle helps but coordination problems remain, meetings take too much time or results call for a different approach.

What would make you stop?

Stop if there is no observable value, managers refuse to make time or they use the cycle to judge individual performance.

What will you do if there is too little evidence?

Record what remains unknown. Agree whether another limited cycle could provide useful evidence.

Complete When we will continue, adapt or stop. Name who makes the final decision and include them in Permission we need.

A better result alone does not prove that OKRs caused it. Record other changes that could explain the result.

Prepare for your manager's questions

Use the questions below to prepare specific answers. Check the proposed trade-offs with the teams before the meeting.

"This adds another meeting."

Which meeting, report or task can you replace or postpone?

"Our priorities change too often."

How will you record why a priority changes and what must wait?

"People will try to make the numbers look good."

What evidence will you review besides the number? How will you keep pay and individual reviews separate?

"We already have measures."

Which existing measures will you keep, and which result needs change now?

Complete the proposal on the next page. Open the meeting with the problem, show your proposed cycle and ask for a decision.

Before you leave, record what the manager approved, what remains unresolved, who will act and the next date. If they need more evidence, agree who will find it and when.

Your proposal for the meeting

Use your answers to complete these ten fields. Take a copy to the meeting. Mark any point that still needs agreement.

The problem

The problem, an example you can show and its cost.

The shared goal

The shared objective, the measure, the starting figure, the target and the deadline.

The scope

The part of the service, the teams and what stays outside the test.

Who runs the test

Who organizes the test and which manager can decide what work comes first.

The dates

Cycle start and end dates, an early review of how teams work, and a final review after the last measured day.

The weekly meeting

Who meets, how often, for how long and who records decisions.

What this replaces

The meeting or report this replaces, and how you keep the test separate from individual performance reviews.

What we will check

Starting figures, weekly customer counts, decisions and meeting effort. State what each review will check and what evidence you need to decide.

When we will continue, adapt or stop

When you will continue, adapt or stop the test. Include what you will do if there is too little evidence.

Permission we need

What the manager must approve, what the teams can postpone and who makes the final decision.

Example: a three-month OKR cycle for two teams

This fictional example asks a manager to approve one three-month OKR cycle for two teams. They aim to reduce delays when new customers start using the service. An early review examines decisions and obstacles. The final review examines customer delays and learning. The example uses invented names, dates, observations and decision criteria.

The problem

One team helps new customers start using the service. The other team manages their accounts.

In December 2026, 4 of 20 new customers missed their agreed start date because one team needed unfinished work from the other. All 20 were due to start that month.

In two cases, a team started a task before identifying the work it needed from the other team.

Both teams also accepted new requests. Nobody agreed which existing tasks could wait.

The shared goal

Objective: reduce avoidable delays when new customers start using the service.

Measure customers whose agreed start date falls between 1 January and 31 March 2027. Count each customer once.

Measure the share who miss their agreed date because work from either team is missing. Include customers who are still waiting after that date.

Key result: reduce that share from 20% to 10% or less by 31 March 2027.

Both teams use this goal to choose which work comes first. Leaders explain which tasks can wait, so people know what they can stop doing.

The scope

The cycle covers two teams and one part of the service: helping new customers start using it.

Keep the measures we already use to track finances and daily work. Any wider use needs a separate decision.

Who runs the test

Ana, product lead, organizes the test and records decisions. Luis, area director, decides which tasks can wait when priorities conflict.

The dates

Run the cycle from 1 January to 31 March 2027.

On 29 January, review how the teams work and adjust their approach. Review results and decide the next step on 1 April, after the last measured day.

The weekly meeting

Both teams meet for 20 minutes each week. They bring results, risks and decisions they need. Ana records each decision and who must act.

What this replaces

Use this meeting instead of the current weekly status meeting. Keep regular team planning. Keep the cycle separate from pay and individual performance reviews.

Example: reviews and permission

What we will check

Before the cycle, Luis and the teams agree what customer data and recorded decisions they need for a useful review.

Ana records current tasks, known needs between the teams and the starting customer figures.

Each week, Ana counts customers whose agreed start date falls in that week. Count each customer once.

Record delays caused by missing work from either team, including customers still waiting after that date. Ana adds the weekly counts for the final review.

Ana also records decisions, when teams report work they need from each other, and time spent in meetings.

On 29 January, check whether the teams understand the shared goal and report needs early. Review priority decisions and meeting effort. Adjust the work without requiring the final result.

On 1 April, compare the delay rate with the 20% starting figure and the 10% target. Report the customer counts too.

If no customers were due to start, report that there is no customer evidence. Do not report a 0% delay rate.

Both teams say whether the weekly meeting helped a decision. Luis and the teams use these questions to discuss usefulness. The answers do not automatically decide whether to continue.

- Did we record at least two decisions about which work to do first and which work could wait?
- Can both teams explain the shared goal?
- Did we identify a need for work from the other team before starting the task that needed that work?

When we will continue, adapt or stop

At the final review, Luis and the teams assess customer results, decisions and learning.

Stop if the cycle provides no observable value. Also stop if managers refuse to make time or use the cycle to judge individual performance.

Continue for another limited cycle when decisions and coordination improve and meeting time is manageable. Use customer results to agree the next action.

Progress and useful learning can justify another cycle even if the teams miss the target.

Adapt the next cycle if it helps, but coordination problems remain or meetings take too much time. Change the approach when customer results call for it.

If there is too little evidence, record what remains unknown. Agree whether another limited cycle could provide useful evidence.

A better result alone does not prove that OKRs caused it. Note other changes that could explain the result.

Permission we need

Approve the three-month cycle and Ana and Luis in their roles.

Let the teams postpone less important work within the agreed area.

Reserve time for weekly meetings, the early review on 29 January and the final review on 1 April 2027.

Decide the next step after reviewing results and learning.

Keep the guide and article together

[Read How to sell OKRs internally](#)

[the Adevinata case on scaling OKR practice](#)

Read the What Matters [explanation of Objectives and Key Results](#)

[Discuss your organizational problem with Marc](#)